

The Terai-Duar Savannas

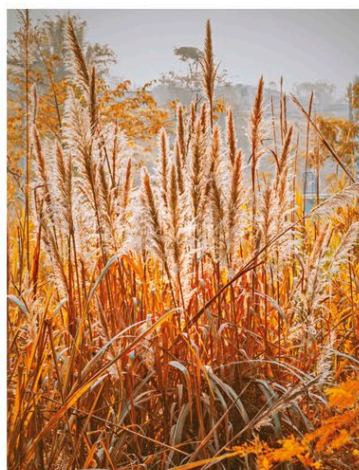
A fertile band at the base of the Himalayas, where Earth's tallest grasses grow



Forming a narrow belt of savanna and marshy grassland dotted with remnants of old forests, the Terai-Duar stretches from the southern Himalayan foothills in Nepal eastward to Bhutan and India. Several rivers, including the Ganges, flow into the region, creating vast alluvial fans of sand, silt, and gravel—ideal for grass and reed growth.

A forest of grass

The Terai's grasses are the tallest in the world, with some species, collectively known as elephant grass, reaching heights of 22 ft (7 m) or more. These grass forests, as they are known, provide perfect cover for hoofed mammals such as swamp deer, pygmy hogs, and buffalo, and the region's national parks are a sanctuary for the Indian rhinoceros and Bengal tiger. The ecoregion also supports mugger crocodiles and rare gharials, as well as many species of birds, including three species found nowhere else on Earth.



△ **FIRST FLOWERS**
Kans grass is the first grass to germinate after the floodwaters retreat in the Terai-Duar.



The Eastern Steppe

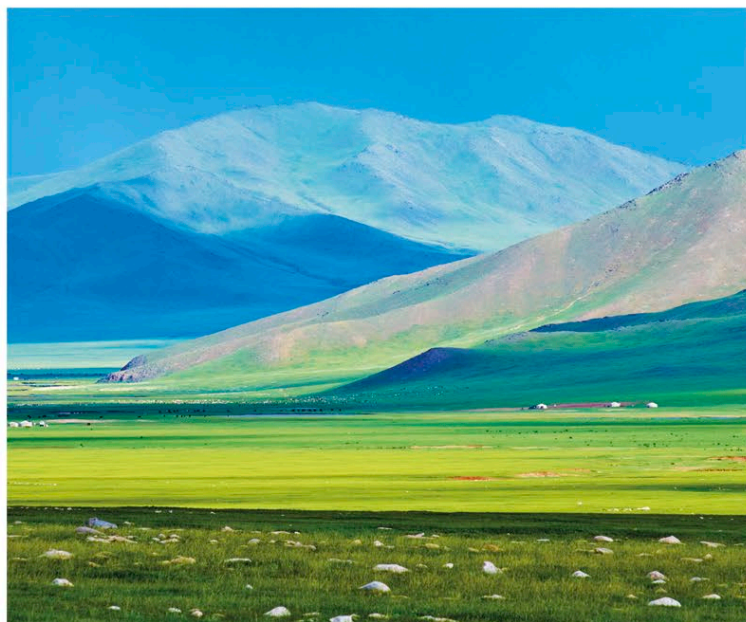
The largest intact temperate grassland on Earth, encompassing a vast, unbroken, windblown plain and prone to seasonal temperature extremes



Part of the huge Eurasian Steppe, the Eastern Steppe is dominated by grasslands across most of its 342,600 square miles (887,330 square km). It extends from southern Siberia to the coastal hills of northeast China and from the Altai Mountains east to the Greater Khingan range.

Harsh land of extremes

This is a much harsher region than its counterpart, the Western Steppe (see p.175), so it has not been subjected to as much agricultural activity. However, the grazing of sheep and goats remains a constant threat to what is a fragile and easily degraded habitat. The region receives just 10–20 in (250–500 mm) of precipitation a year, but hardy grass species manage to grow, despite a temperature range of -4°F (-20°C) in winter to 104°F (40°C) in summer. At higher elevations, rainfall increases, and snow accumulated on mountain peaks descends as streams into the dry lands below.



◁ STEPPE COUNTRY

The Eastern Steppe's vast grasslands in Mongolia look empty, yet are rich enough to feed a diverse range of wildlife, from marmots and grazing animals to many birds of prey.